'No, you keep it. It's yours.'

'But it could have remained in the tree for another twenty-five years if you hadn't climbed up to look for it.'

1. What did the visitor hide in the jackfruit tree?
2. When did the visitor actually hide the iron cross?

'But if you hadn't come back again....'

'On the right day, at the right time, and with the right person', he said, getting up and placing the medal in her hands. 'It wasn't the Cross I came for. It was my youth.'

She didn't understand that, but she walked with him to the gate and waited. Where the road turned, he looked back and waved to her. Then he quickened his steps and moved briskly towards the bus stop. There was sprightliness in his step, and something cried aloud in his heart.

The mango scented summer breeze made the blood course in his veins, and he forgot, for a moment, that he couldn't climb trees any more....

Glossary

turnstile (n) **:**
a mechanical gate consisting of revolving horizontal arms fixed to a vertical post, allowing only one person at a time to pass through

hollyhocks (n) **:**
a tall Eurasian plant of the mallow family, with large showy flowers

colonel (n) **:**
a rank of officer in the army

brigadier (n) **:**
a rank of officer in the British army, above Colonel

trapeze (n) **:**
a horizontal bar hanging by two ropes and free to swing, used by acrobats in a circus

About the author



Ruskin Bond was born on 19th May 1934. He is an award winning Indian author of British descent. He is much renowned for his role in promoting children's literature in India. The Indian council for Child Education has recognized his role in the growth of children's literature in India. He got the Sahitya Akademi Award in 1992 for *'Our Trees Still Grow in Dehra'*. He was awarded the Padmashri in 1999 and Padma Bhushan in 2014. As a prolific writer, he has written over 500 short stories, essays and novels. His popular novel *'The Blue Umbrella'* was made into a Hindi film and was awarded the National Film Award for the best children's film in 2007.

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